Sandbox sales

A practice till for training staff. Sales rung on it never reach your books, though the stock still comes off the shelf.

What it is

Sandbox mode turns the till into a practice machine. A new starter can ring sales, take payment and print receipts exactly as they would for a real customer, and none of it touches your figures. No money is recorded, and nothing shows up in your reports or End of day. Stock is the one thing it does not hold back.

Turning it on and off

Press `Ctrl` + `Shift` + `S`. There is no button for it anywhere, so the shortcut is the only way in or out.

- Only a Manager or Administrator can turn it on, and you will be asked for your PIN even though you are already signed in.
- For anyone below that level the shortcut simply does nothing.
- Turning it off is not restricted at all: no PIN, and any user can do it.
- The sale on screen has to be empty, going in or coming out, so finish or clear it first.

While sandbox mode is on, a SANDBOX MODE badge sits at the top of the sales screen, next to the menu button. No badge means you are on the live till.

What changes

On the practice till	Why
Cash is the only payment method	Card and account payments would pull in real terminals and real customer balances.
Stock is deducted, as normal	Goods handed to a trainee have left the shelf. A count that ignored them would drift away from what is actually in the shop.
Receipt numbers start with `SBX-`	Practice sales never use up one of your real receipt numbers, so there are no gaps in them.
The main menu is blocked	Management, Settings and End of day cannot be reached from a practice till.
A Sandbox sales button appears in the top bar	With the menu blocked, this is the only way to review practice sales.

Where practice sales show up

Location	Practice sales included?
Sales history	No
Reports	No
End of day / Z-report	No
Stock levels	Yes, deducted like any sale
Sandbox sales screen	Yes, and only here

Stock still comes off the shelf

Ring up six bottles and hand them over, and six bottles have left the shop. The count drops by six, and your low-stock warnings react exactly as they would to a real sale. If training did not take stock off, your counts would drift further from the shelf every time somebody practised.

If nothing actually left the shop, say a trainee just tapping through the screens, put the count back in Management → Stock afterwards.

The till also assumes whatever expires soonest goes out first. When it works out what is left on the shelf it counts the batches dated furthest ahead as the ones remaining, so an expiry warning always points at the nearest date. What matters is the expiry date, not when the delivery arrived. A later delivery with a shorter shelf life is used up before an earlier one that keeps longer. Practice sales count towards this the same as real ones.

The till is assuming, not checking. It has no way of knowing which pack a member of staff actually reached for, so the warnings are only as good as the rotation on the shelf.

Reviewing and clearing practice sales

Tap Sandbox sales in the top bar. Two buttons live there that you will not find anywhere else.

Delete all sandbox sales clears the practice sales in the period currently on screen, not everything ever rung. Your real sales are never touched, and it cannot be undone.

Add this sale to live DB moves one practice sale into your real books. You want this only when a genuine customer sale was rung by mistake while the till was in sandbox mode.

What happens to the receipt number

Adding a practice sale to live gives it a fresh number from your real receipt numbering, and the old one is written over. Nothing keeps a copy of it. Someone holding `SBX-26-200-000001` is holding a number that no longer exists on the till, and searching for it finds nothing. The sale might now be `26-200-000002`. The digits moved as well, so it is not the old number with the `SBX-` stripped off.

Reprint the receipt and give the customer the new one. Stock does not change, because it came off when the sale was originally rung. None of this can be undone.

Finding a sale after you have added it to live

It disappears from the Sandbox sales screen as soon as you add it, because it is not a sandbox sale any more. Look for it in Management → Documents, alongside your real sales.

The number is the only thing that changed, so there is plenty left to go on. If the sale had a customer on it, the quickest way in is the Customer filter: pick the name and the list drops to that customer's sales. A walk-in sale has no customer attached, so that filter will not help there.

Otherwise go by date. Set the Period to the day the sale was originally rung rather than the day you added it, since the sale keeps its own date and time. The time, the total and the ID column are all untouched as well.

Watch the dates while you look. The new number is issued against today, but the sale is still dated when it happened. A sale rung on Monday and added to live on Friday gets a Friday-style number while sitting under Monday in the list. Search Monday.

Everyday use

- Turn it on for training and off again as soon as you are done. A till left in sandbox mode takes no real money, and every sale rung on it is thrown away.
- Look for the SANDBOX MODE badge before serving a customer.
- Clear practice sales now and then so the Sandbox sales screen stays readable.
- The two tills share one product list, one price list and one set of staff, so changing a price changes it for both.

Low stock warnings

The till tells you what is running out, so you notice before a customer does.

Where the warnings appear

A red badge on the menu button counts everything needing attention. Open the menu and it takes you to Stock alerts, where each product is listed with the reason it is there.

The same products are highlighted in Management → Stock, in a column called Needs attention. It is one list shown in two places.

When a product counts as low

Each product is judged against a threshold. If the quantity on hand is at or below it, the product is flagged. At or below, not under: with a threshold of 5 and 5 on the shelf, that is already the moment to reorder rather than a near miss.

Out of stock always counts, whatever the threshold says.

Setting the level

There are two places to set it, and a product only needs one of them.

- Settings → Order & payment → Items has Low stock threshold. This covers every product that has no figure of its own.
- Management → Products, editing a product, has Low stock threshold (optional). Fill it in and that product ignores the shop-wide figure.

The shop-wide figure starts at 0, so out of the box you are only warned once something has actually run out. Raise it and every product without its own figure starts warning at the new level, so expect the badge to jump the first time you change it.

Turning it off for a product

Some products have no shelf to run out of. Services, gift cards and open-price items will sit at zero for ever and warn for ever.

Edit the product and switch Low stock alerts off. Clearing the threshold box will not do it: an empty box means fall back to the shop-wide figure. The switch is what says never. Expiry warnings are unaffected either way.

Products marked inactive never appear either, since you cannot sell them anyway.

Choosing a number

The useful threshold is however much you sell while a delivery is on its way, plus a little. A line that sells two a day on a weekly order wants a threshold nearer fifteen than three.

Setting it too high is the more common mistake. Every product over its threshold sits in the badge count, and a badge showing forty is a badge nobody reads.

Expiry dates

Record what arrived and when it goes off, and the till warns you before it does.

Recording dates as a delivery is booked in

The usual place is the purchase itself. In Management → Documents, add a Purchase document for the delivery, and each line has an Expiry date (optional) field alongside the quantity and cost.

Saving the purchase adds a dated line to the expiry register by itself, noted against the purchase number so you can see where it came from. The date is typed once, while you have the box in your hand, and the purchase doubles as the record of what arrived and how long it was good for.

The field only appears on purchases. A sale, refund, return or write-off has no delivery date to record, so you will not see it there.

Dates are picked up the first time a purchase is saved. Going back into a saved purchase later will not add the delivery to the register a second time.

Record whichever date is printed on the pack, whether that is a use by or a best before. The till treats them the same and just counts down to it.

Recording a date afterwards

When a delivery was booked in without dates, or arrived before anyone was recording them, Management → Stock has an expiry entry flyout on the product: how much and the date on it.

Adjusting a product's quantity has the same field, and it dates only the units the change adds. It is ignored when the quantity stays the same or goes down, since nothing new arrived to date.

Either way, a product can hold several entries at once, which is normal when a new delivery lands before the last one has sold through. The older date carries on warning you after the newer stock arrives.

Nothing forces you to record dates at all. A product with no entries simply never raises an expiry warning.

When the warnings start

Warnings begin a set number of days before the date, and there are two states. Expiring soon means the date is coming up inside that window. Expired means the date has passed.

- Settings → Order & payment → Items has Expiry warning (days), which starts at 3 and covers every product without its own figure.
- Management → Products, editing a product, has Expiry warning days (optional) for anything that needs longer or shorter notice.

Three days suits chilled food. For a frozen or ambient line you would rather shift a fortnight early, set a longer figure on that product rather than raising the shop-wide one, or everything else starts warning far too early.

Expiry outranks low stock

A product can be both low and near its date. You will see the expiry reason, because that is the one with a deadline on it.

The order is worst first: expired, then expiring soon, then low. The top of the list is always the thing to handle first.

What the wording on screen means

The badge on the menu button counts everything at once, in the form 4 item(s) need attention: 1 expired, 2 expiring soon, 1 low on stock.

In Management → Stock, the Needs attention column is more specific. `6 expiring 17 Aug` means six units are covered by an entry dated the seventeenth. `Expired 6 on 10 Aug` means that date has already passed.

Open a product's expiry entries and each one carries its own status.

- `in 5d` counts down to the date. It turns amber once inside the warning window.
- `Expires today` and `Expired 3d ago` speak for themselves.
- `Assumed sold` means stock on hand no longer reaches this entry, so the till has concluded it went out. It stops warning but stays on record, and comes back by itself if a recount puts the stock back up.
- `Cleared` means the entry has been closed off, either because somebody ticked it off or because the product hit zero and the till closed its open entries automatically. Unlike Assumed sold, this one is permanent.

How overlapping deliveries are handled

Selling something does not change what you recorded. Sell six bottles and the stock count drops, but the entry still says six arrived on that date. The till cannot know which pack actually went over the counter.

Instead it works backwards from the stock on hand, assuming the soonest-dated stock left first and counting whatever remains as the newest. So an older delivery that has sold through stops warning by itself, and the warning you see always points at the soonest date still covered by stock actually on the shelf.

That is an assumption, not a check. If staff hand over the newest pack because a customer reached to the back of the shelf, the till believes the older one is gone when it is still there. Rotating stock properly is what makes it true.

The Stock tab shows a Next expiry column, which is the soonest date stock still covers, so you can see what it has concluded.

Clearing an entry

When stock has been thrown away or sold through, tick the entry off. It stops warning but stays on record, so you can still look back at what was wasted last month.

If a product drops to zero the till clears its open entries by itself, since there is nothing left to go off.

Clearing is one way, however it happened. A cleared entry never warns again, so when stock comes back it needs a new entry with the new date. Assumed sold is the opposite: it is only the till reading the current count, and it undoes itself.

Slow moving stock

Which products are sitting on the shelf not selling, and how much money is stuck in them.

What it is for

Low stock warnings tell you what to reorder. This is the opposite question: what did you buy that nobody is buying back. Every one of those lines is money sitting on a shelf instead of in the till.

Where to find it

- Management → Reporting has the full Slow moving report, with a period picker and filters for a single product or category.
- The Dashboard carries a shorter Slow moving card, showing the worst offenders at a glance.

What counts as slow

A product appears when it has stock on hand and has not sold for longer than the shop's slow moving period. That period is in Settings → Order & payment → Items, under Slow moving after (days), and starts at 90.

Retail generally uses somewhere between 90 and 180 days. The right number depends on what you sell: a delicatessen counting in weeks and a hardware shop counting in seasons should not use the same figure.

Reading the report

Rows are sorted slowest first, so the top of the list is the stock that has sat longest. The bar beside each row is the money tied up in it, which is quantity multiplied by what it cost you.

A long bar near the top is the row worth acting on: old stock and a lot of money in it. A long bar low down is simply an expensive product that still sells.

Products that have never sold at all appear too. Usually that is something ordered once that never found its customer.

What the period does, and does not, do

This is the part that catches people out. The period you pick does not decide which products are listed. Whether a product is slow is judged against its last sale across the whole of your history, not just the window on screen.

The period only fills in the sold in period column, which is there for context. So a product last sold two years ago still shows up with the period set to this month. That is the report working, not a mistake.

What is left out

- Products with nothing on hand. A line you have sold out of is not tying up any money.
- Inactive products, which you cannot sell anyway.
- Practice sales rung in sandbox mode, which never count as sales here.

Acting on it

The usual moves are to discount it, move it somewhere customers actually look, bundle it with something that does sell, or stop reordering it. The report will not tell you which, but it does tell you where the money is, and that is the part which is hard to see from behind the counter.

Worth a look monthly. Checked more often than that, nothing has changed since last time.